

The Claremont City Council held a meeting on Wednesday, December 9, 2020, in the Council Chambers of City Hall and via Zoom.

The meeting was called to order by Mayor Lovett at 6:30 p.m.

Mayor Lovett read the following statement: *This meeting is being conducted in accordance with the provisions of the Governor's Executive Order no. 2020-04 and the emergency meeting provisions of RSA 91-A to permit participation of board members by electronic means. Under the conditions of the current COVID-19 pandemic and the protocols established by the Centers for Disease Control (CDC), it is not reasonably practical for a quorum of this board's members to attend this meeting in person.*

To join the webinar by telephone:

1-646-558-8656

Webinar ID: 882 3823 3399

Passcode: 376500

If there is a problem getting through to that number, please call 603-542-7002.

Members of the Council present, including location and who was in the room:

Ward I Councilor Andrew O'Hearne – home, alone

At-Large Councilor Abigail Kier – home, alone

At-Large Councilor Erica Sweetser – Council Chambers, Councilor Stone

Assistant Mayor Allen Damren – home, alone

Mayor Charlene Lovett – daughter's apartment, daughter

At-Large Councilor Debora Matteau – home, alone

At-Large Councilor Nicholas Koloski – work, alone

Ward II Councilor James Contois – home, alone

Ward III Councilor Jonathan Stone – Council Chambers, Councilors Sweetser

Also present:

Edward Morris, City Manager

AGENDA CHANGES

None.

REPORT OF THE SECRETARY

A motion was made by Assistant Mayor Damren and seconded by Councilor Stone to accept the minutes of the November 4, 2020, City Council meeting, as amended.

Mayor Lovett said there was no discussion in the minutes about whether or not the Call Firefighters were included in the study, she said she believed the answer was no, and she believes there was direction from the Council to have some analysis done with regard to that. She said she did not have a chance to review the recording, but believes that was the gist of the discussion.

Roll call vote:

O’Hearne - yes

Kier - yes

Sweetser - abstain

Damren - yes

Matteau - yes

Koloski - yes

Contois - yes

Stone - yes

Lovett - yes

Motion carried 8-0, 1 abstain.

A motion was made by Councilor Matteau and seconded by Councilor Kier to accept the minutes of the November 12, 2020, City Council meeting, as amended.

Councilor Koloski said on page 10, where it said that “Councilors Kier and Koloski had proposed an ordinance mandating face masks with fines for violating the ordinance” is not what occurred. He said a sample ordinance was presented to the Council by Councilors Koloski and Kier for conversation.

Roll call vote:

O’Hearne - yes

Kier - yes

Sweetser – abstain (not present at the meeting)

Damren - yes

Matteau - yes

Koloski - yes

Contois - yes

Stone - yes

Lovett - yes

Motion carried 8-0, 1 abstain.

MAYOR’S NOTES

Mayor Lovett said the changes that were made for making a socially distant and safe Holiday Lighting of Broad Street Park and Santa’s visit was well received and much appreciated.

Councilor Kier announced her resignation from all City roles effective January 3, 2021, as she will be relocating to the DC area for her husband’s new job.

Councilors shared their appreciation for the work that Councilor Kier has done for the City of Claremont and that she will be missed.

Mayor Lovett said that appointment of a new Councilor will have to be completed by the second regular meeting in January.

Councilor Koloski said during Santa's parade that he had heard good comments about the parade from people who don't live here.

Councilor Koloski wanted to call attention to the fact that Claremont has a very active Conservation Commission. Councilor Contois commented that the Conservation Commission Chair, Gary Dickerman, works diligently.

Councilor Contois said the holiday season is rapidly approaching and that Councilor Koloski is always offering food, help, equipment, etc., to those who need it and he thanked Councilor Koloski for his civic mindedness. Councilor Contois said that Mayor Lovett is working with the Claremont-Sugar River Rotary Club handing out masks and food; he thanked her for her spirit of giving.

CITY MANAGER'S REPORT

Mr. Morris thanked Parks and Recreation Director Mark Brislin, Police Chief Mark Chase, and Fire Chief Bryan Burr, for all their work to make the Holiday Lighting of Broad Street Park and Santa's visit work. He continued thanking Mr. Brislin and his department for all their work on COVID friendly events.

- **Backflow Prevention** – Public Works has been working with the New Hampshire Department of Environmental Services to create a plan to bring all backflow prevention devices up to date and to maintain compliance. He thanked Shane Stone, the City's Cross Connection Technician, for taking on this project and working with the State of New Hampshire to create a plan and correct a long-term deficiency within the City.
- **Alex Gleeson** – He introduced Alex Gleeson, the City's new Public Works Director, who joined the City on November 30, 2020.
- **SRF Funding** – The City has applied for a normal SRF loan for \$2 Million, and has also applied for the New Hampshire Drinking Water and Groundwater Trust Fund for another \$2 Million. The intent behind applying for both SRF Loan Funds was to receive the most forgiveness possible for the total \$2 Million funding. City Staff has received confirmation from the State of New Hampshire that we will receive \$1.5 Million from the normal SRF Fund, and \$500,000 from the New Hampshire Drinking Water and Groundwater Trust Fund. Together these equal \$2 Million from which

\$500,000 (Trust Fund portion) will be forgiven and of the other \$1.5 Million, will receive a 10% forgiveness of the principle. This means a total of \$650,000 of the \$2 Million will be forgiven leaving a total loan payment of \$1,350,000. This money will be used to replace older water lines, and will accelerate the City's "Get the Lead Out" initiative. This will come back to the Council for the bond process.

- **137-149 Main Street** – Pine Hill Construction is in the final phases of shoring up 149 Main Street, and the plan was to start the demolition of 137 Main Street next week. East bound traffic will be rerouted to Union Street, with the road remaining open to west bound traffic. Pine Hill Construction estimated the road will be closed for 1-2 days, and the entire demolition will take about a week. However, a final walkthrough showed there was some active electrical in the building. It may take a few days for Eversource to remove it.
- **Peterson Mill Update-** Chinburg Properties has submitted amended site plans to City Staff. This project will be going to the Planning Board for site plan review on Dec 28th. The plan is consistent with the prior approved plan, with the exception of a request for 2 additional feet of easement area east of the building for landscaping, and a need for additional surface parking. The Planning Board will discuss parking requirements as part of the site plan. Both the easement and parking agreements are scheduled to be on the agenda of the first City Council meeting in January.
- **Tax Bills** – The Assessing Department ran the City's tax warrant on December 1, 2020, and the Clerks are currently working on getting the tax bills printed and mailed by Monday, December 7, 2020. The due date for the first payment will be January 8, 2021. He thanked the Assessing Department and the City Clerk's office for all the work they put into streamlining this process. What used to take a week or more to accomplish is now completed in about one working day.
- **WMUR-** City Staff is currently hearing that WMUR will continue to be carried in Claremont and surrounding towns, and will not be dropped on December 22, 2020 as announced by Comcast. Comcast is still in negotiations with Hearst Broadcasting; however, the most recent news continues to be encouraging. The City of Claremont Staff will continue to watch this situation, and update the City Council and residents as information is received.
- **Viewpoint Citizen Concerns-** The City has launched our Citizen Concern link. This short application is featured under the City Manager page on the City's website, and is a place for people to share concerns about illegal dumping, graffiti, trash accumulation, etc.
- The gate on Broad Street into Monadnock Park has been closed for the winter. People can still access Monadnock Park through the Chestnut Street entrance.

- **COVID-19 Update** – As of the time this report was written, the State of New Hampshire continues to see an increase in positive COVID-19 cases, and we continue to see open community transmission throughout Claremont and Sullivan County. Claremont currently has 10 active cases, and has been maintaining numbers between 10 and 15 cases for the past few weeks. In order to maintain these numbers in Claremont, we must increase our efforts to control the spread of the virus. We are expecting an increase in cases over the next week from the Thanksgiving holiday, but if we increase our social distancing, and wearing masks when in public, along with maintaining hand hygiene and sanitization efforts, we may be able to minimize the spike.
- As of earlier today, Claremont has 14 active cases. Also, the City of Claremont has had a couple of employees test positive. Employees are being isolated, when needed. There is open community transmission within the City now.

While attending the Mayors' meeting with U.S. Senator Hassan, she asked us to emphasize the science behind the vaccine. The science behind this vaccine has been in the works for years, but the gearing up and production has been fast tracked. Senator Hassan encouraged the citizens of Claremont and New Hampshire to get vaccinated once the vaccine is available, so we can get back to normal as soon as possible.

Councilor Koloski talked about the Emergency Vehicle Technician Certification that was mentioned in the Fire Department Report and asked as Public Works vehicle technicians become certified if that information will come back to the Council. Mr. Morris said he can talk to Chief Burr about that.

Councilor Koloski asked about City actions on private properties that are in the Planning and Development Report and how the City recovers that money. Mr. Morris said the City sometimes has to expend funds to clean up areas that have become health issues; and then the City works to recover the funds through small claims Court or working with our attorney to get a Court action.

Councilor Koloski said some boards are missing from the empty Home Town Deli building. Mr. Morris said that is being worked on.

Councilor Matteau asked about putting liens on properties that the City expends funds to clean up. Mr. Morris said that is also an option.

Councilor Koloski pointed out the savings being realized by Public Works through a change in their software.

Councilor Koloski asked if, due to COVID, Welfare Director Suzanne Carr, will be coming to the Council to ask for additional funding. Mr. Morris said as of now, no, but that is being watched.

Councilor Koloski said he was happy to see the new Citizen Concern link online. He asked if it could be made clear that there is no anonymity through this process.

Councilor Stone asked how the City is tracking homeless people in Claremont. Mr. Morris said through the Welfare Department and Southwestern Community Services. Mayor Lovett said she has been doing research on homelessness and will send the information to the Council.

APPOINTMENT TO BOARDS AND COMMITTEES

Claremont Development Authority

A motion was made by Councilor Koloski and seconded by Assistant Mayor Damren to re-appoint Derek Ferland to seat 8 of the Claremont Development Authority.

Roll call vote:

O'Hearne - yes

Kier - yes

Sweetser - yes

Damren - yes

Matteau - yes

Koloski - yes

Contois - yes

Stone - yes

Lovett - yes

Motion carried 9-0.

A motion was made by Councilor Matteau and seconded by Councilor Kier to re-appoint Candace Crawford to seat 7 of the Claremont Development Authority.

Roll call vote:

O'Hearne - yes

Kier - yes

Sweetser - yes

Damren - yes

Matteau - yes

Koloski - yes

Contois - yes

Stone - yes

Lovett - yes

Motion carried 9-0.

A motion was made by Assistant Mayor Damren and seconded by Councilor Matteau to re-appoint Michael Satzow to seat 9 of the Claremont Development Authority.

Roll call vote:

O'Hearne - yes

Kier - yes

Sweetser - yes
Damren - yes
Matteau - yes
Koloski - yes
Contois - yes
Stone - yes
Lovett - yes
Motion carried 9-0.

Fiske Free Library Board of Trustees

A motion was made by Councilor Kier and seconded by Councilor Matteau to appoint Sharon Wood to seat 3 of the Fiske Free Library Board of Trustees.

Roll call vote:
O'Hearne - yes
Kier - yes
Sweetser - yes
Damren - yes
Matteau - yes
Koloski - yes
Contois - yes
Stone - yes
Lovett - yes
Motion carried 9-0.

Historic District Commission

A motion was made by Assistant Mayor Damren and seconded by Councilor Stone to appoint Bill Kennedy to seat 3 of the Historic District Commission.

Roll call vote:
O'Hearne - yes
Kier - no
Sweetser - yes
Damren - yes
Matteau - yes
Koloski - yes
Contois - yes
Stone - yes
Lovett - yes
Motion carried 8-1.

CITIZEN'S FORUM

No one spoke.

OLD BUSINESS

Proposed Council Rule Change (Citizen Letters)

Option A:

A citizen's request to have a letter either read or entered into the record will only be granted if a Council member finds the letter compelling and is willing to adopt that letter as an expression of his or her own opinion on the issue before the City Council. If the citizen's request is to read the letter into the record and a Councilor is willing to adopt it as an expression of his or her own opinion, then that Councilor shall read the letter into the record. A copy of the letter will be attached to the meeting minutes.

Option B:

A citizen's request to have a letter either read or entered into the record shall be granted by the City Council. If the citizen's request is to have the letter read into the record, it will be read by the Clerk to the Council. A copy of the letter will be attached to the meeting minutes.

Mayor Lovett gave some background.

After discussion, Mayor Lovett asked how many Councilors were in favor of having no member of the Council read letters into the record. A majority raised their hands. Mayor Lovett said she would go to NHMA (New Hampshire Municipal Association) for assistance writing a Rule that that no Councilors would read letters from citizens. A letter would have to be read by the writer, or someone of their choosing.

License Agreement for Use of City Land – Map 133-57, Map 133-58, and Map 133-59

Mr. Morris said this is the Rail Trail in front of Mike Hurd's property, 297-299 Washington Street. He met with Mr. Hurd and it was agreed to not put up a fence in between Mr. Hurd's two driveways and that signs will be posted showing where the parking is. This will allow bigger trucks to be able to move through that area. This is a request to authorize the City Manager to enter into a license agreement with Mr. Hurd. He said that Mr. Hurd will pay property taxes on that portion of land.

Mr. Morris said that Mr. Hurd had asked that the money that he will pay on this portion of land be put toward Special Olympics, but that is not needed. Mr. Morris suggested the money be set aside for Rail Trail maintenance.

Jim Feleen, Ward 2, said that he was speaking for himself. He said that when the Rail Trail was purchased, there was a stipulation that no motorized vehicles would be allowed on the Rail Trail, however, the City has not enforced that rule. He had concerns about that. Also, he had concerns about liability issues by licensing an abutter to use the property.

Mr. Morris said the City can double check this. Regarding the liability concern, Mr. Hurd will maintain insurance on the property.

A majority of the Councilors agreed that the City should receive written approval of these actions before going forward with a licensing agreement with Mr. Hurd.

Legislative Update

Mayor Lovett gave an update:

1. Mayors' Letter on Homelessness/Governor Sununu's Response

Background:

The mayors of the 13 NH cities held a roundtable discussion in October to identify common areas of concern in preparation for the upcoming legislative session. Mayors identified homelessness, potential revenue shortfalls in the upcoming budget, and affordable housing as the three top areas of concern. City Manager Morris also attended the roundtable.

Recommendation:

The Governor also asked the cities to support legislative action that results in an increase in housing stock as it is an essential component to decreasing homelessness. Legislative initiatives regarding zoning and development incentives will be a part of the upcoming session. Such initiatives align with goals/objectives in our Master Plan, and Mayor Lovett recommended that the City follow these bills closely.

2. Potential Revenue Shortfalls:

Background:

Municipalities across the state are concerned with potential shortfalls in state revenue, particularly in education funding. At a mayors' roundtable in November, concerns were raised about changes in student enrollment. Another concern shared was the number of households completing free and reduced lunch forms. Both enrollment and completed application forms affect the amount of funding that school districts receive.

Recommendation:

The City Council and the School Board have not held a joint meeting since 2018. We have been successful in previous joint advocacy efforts. If we are to repeat this in the upcoming legislative session, Mayor Lovett recommended reinstituting some type of joint effort. If it is not at the governing body level, perhaps it could be delegated to the committee level (the

school district's budget committee/the Council's finance committee) or between the School Board Chair/Superintendent and the Mayor/City Manager?

Councilors agreed that the Mayor, City Manager, School Superintendent, and School Board Chair should meet to discuss this.

3. Housing Affordability

Background:

In addition to the legislative initiatives cited in the Governor's letter to facilitate an increase in the housing stock, the mayors discussed the need to engage the federal delegation in this discussion as incentives for housing development originate at the federal level.

Recommendation:

Advocate for federal incentives that would make the redevelopment of vacant/underutilized buildings and construction of new buildings economically feasible.

Councilors agreed with the recommendation.

4. Meet with Claremont legislators in January

Background:

In years past, the City Council has met with Claremont's legislators to discuss the municipality's legislative priorities for the upcoming session. This has occurred during either a joint meeting of the Council/School Board or at a regularly scheduled Council meeting. By doing so, the City is well positioned to effectively advocate during the legislation session which moves rather quickly.

Recommendation:

Meet with our state legislators as early as possible in January to discuss legislative priorities/concerns. If there is consensus to do so, the Council should decide whether it prefers the discussion to take place in a joint setting or as an agenda item at a Council meeting.

Councilors agreed to have this as an agenda item in January.

Funds Transfer (Compensation)

City Staff met with the Personnel Advisory Board (PAB) to discuss the Compensation Study, and receive their input and recommendation on how to proceed.

The PAB recommended the City Staff move forward with completing the Merit Plan review and preparing it for submission to the City Council. As part of this review, they made a motion to adjust all salary scales in the Merit Plan in accordance with the parameters set forth in the Compensation Study (7.5% between grades with a 60% spread from minimum salary to maximum salary). Based on the City's demographics and financial situation, the PAB recommends that the salary scales be set at the 40th percentile for now, and not the 50th, with the recommendation that the Council look at adjusting the findings in the study to target the 40th-45th percentile.

Also discussed was Mr. Morris' plan to address raises with larger raises going to employees that were farthest away from the percentile target, and not to differentiate between Merit or Union employees. The PAB, though focused on the Merit employees, agreed to this approach. After further discussion about this year's budget and Mr. Morris' plan to use a portion of what was budgeted for increases, and keeping some to encumber into next year, the PAB made a motion to recommend the City Council approve transferring \$62,136 from fund 417 to the appropriate funds for the purpose of giving salary increases in January 2021.

Mr. Morris said the Council agreed during the budget process to move \$90,000 to the 417 line item in order to address the Compensation Study. With COVID unknowns, there is a need to be conservative, therefore his recommendation is to move only \$62,136 from the 417 line. He would like to do this in January. Employees got a 2% increase last year, but previously many did not get raises. The Finance Committee has asked what the total impact would be next year. He will talk with them about that and asked to move this motion to the first Council meeting in January.

Mr. Morris said the PAB has almost completed review of the Merit Plan. They should meet next week and will discuss moving 26 Merit Plan employees from 7% to 10% health insurance.

Candy Crawford, Personnel Advisory Board Chair, said that the PAB has reviewed the Compensation Study and is very impressed with the thoroughness of the report. Twenty-four similar communities were asked to participate and 23 did. That gave strong data to the report. One thing that is significant is that this report found 161 positions were found to be substantially below market rate based and 17 positions were below market. Given that data, she said the PAB urges the Council to adopt some of the results of this report. Also, the PAB supports making adjustments to salaries sooner rather than later. It was suggested this be done over 5 years. It is important to show employees that they are valued by taking action.

Claire Lessard, Personnel Advisory Board member, said the recommendations would benefit the furthest behind. She hopes the Council goes with the recommendations.

Mr. Morris said the PAB did recommend to adopt and move the salary scales for the Merit Plan to mimic what the consultants had asked for (keep the 7.5% between grades, and 60% spread between minimum and maximum). They asked that the City move the scales right now to the 40th percentile, not the 50th percentile as reported in the Compensation Study. At the first meeting, the PAB made a recommendation to move to the 40th percentile, and after discussion,

the recommendation was changed to move to between the 40th-45th percentile. The PAB recommends we move the \$62,136 as soon as possible to move forward with the raises. They liked his recommendation of staggered raises, based on how far the employee is behind. He reached out to the three unions and they would welcome the raises he has recommended.

Ms. Crawford said she thinks it is important to send a message to employees that the City Council supported conducting this survey and now it behooves all to support the findings. She encouraged the Council to do so.

Councilor Contois does not support the Compensation Study. He thought it was flawed. He needs more information.

Councilor Matteau said she sits on the Finance Committee and they have started discussing this. She has many concerns. She said if fully implemented, this would be a \$1.2 million increase in salaries going forward.

Mr. Morris said the City is asking the Finance Committee to look at the 40th percentile, which makes quite a difference from what was presented in the Study. He is recommending moving some of the people that are extremely far behind. A lot of people that are 45% behind, are on the low end of the pay scale. He hopes the Council will send this to the Finance Committee and then be able to bring it back to the Council in January. He hopes to move some money in order to give some raises this year.

Councilor O'Hearne said he is not ready to move money until this goes to the Finance Committee. He wants to see where Merit Plan employees are currently. He would like to see that before a decision is made.

Assistant Mayor Damren said he was in favor of doing the study, however, the \$1.2 million was a surprise. The Finance Committee needs 2-3 more meetings to discuss this. He does not want this Study to be put on a shelf and forgotten.

Ms. Crawford said the PAB thought the 40% percentile was more realistic than the 50% percentile. It is important for the City to stay competitive and to pay its employees fairly. \$90,000 had been set aside for catch up, and the City Manager is not looking to spend it all.

A motion was made by Councilor O'Hearne and seconded by Councilor Stone that this be sent to the Finance Committee for additional work.

Councilor Matteau asked that compensation sheets be included in a future Council packet as it is important to look at all benefits.

At 8:30 p.m. Mayor Lovett was absent from the meeting [she was having internet difficulties].

Roll call vote:
O'Hearne - yes

Kier - yes
Sweetser - yes
Damren - yes
Matteau - yes
Koloski - yes
Contois - yes
Stone - yes
Lovett – absent [internet problems]
Motion carried 8-0, Mayor Lovett absent.

Councilor O’Hearne said that it was just announced that the newly elected NH House Speaker has died. He asked for a moment of silence.

At 8:34 p.m. Mayor Lovett returned.

After the Council returned from break, at 8:45 p.m., a moment of silence was observed for the passing of NH’s newly elected House Speaker Hinch.

NEW BUSINESS

Accept Police Vehicle from Claremont Ford

Police Chief Mark Chase said Ford of Claremont would like to donate a vehicle to the Claremont Police Department.

A motion was made by Assistant Mayor Damren and seconded by Councilor Kier that the Claremont City Council hereby accepts with sincere appreciation a donation from Ford of Claremont of a 2021 Ford Police Interceptor utility vehicle with lettering, valued at approximately \$38,000.00, for the Claremont Police Department.

Chief Chase said this is a hybrid vehicle. It will be a K-9 vehicle and it is expected to last about 8 years.

Roll call vote:
O’Hearne - yes
Kier - yes
Sweetser - yes
Damren - yes
Matteau - yes
Koloski - yes
Contois - yes
Stone - yes
Lovett - yes
Motion carried 9-0.

Accept \$11,435 NH Highway Enforcement Grant

Chief Chase gave a brief background. This allows enhanced motor vehicle enforcement, supplemental patrols.

A motion was made by Councilor Kier and seconded by Assistant Mayor Damren to authorize the City Manager, or his designees, to accept and expend a grant in the amount of eleven thousand, four hundred, thirty-five dollars (\$11,435.00) and to enter into an agreement with the Office of Highway Safety for the purpose of specific and focused motor vehicle enforcement to include Speed Enforcement, DUI Enforcement, Join the Clique Campaign, Drive Sober or get pulled over Campaign and U Drive, U Test U Pay Campaign.

Roll call vote:

O'Hearne - yes

Kier - yes

Sweetser - yes

Damren - yes

Matteau - yes

Koloski - yes

Contois - yes

Stone - yes

Lovett - yes

Motion carried 9-0.

Accept \$12,000 Grant from NH Charitable Foundation for Shop with a Cop, and for Safety Equipment for Claremont Police Department

Chief Chase gave some background. Shop with a Cop happens tomorrow.

A motion was made by Assistant Mayor Damren and seconded by Councilor Sweetser that the Claremont City Council hereby accepts with sincere appreciation a grant in the amount of \$2,000 from the New Hampshire Charitable Foundation (Rosebud Fund) for the Shop with a Cop Program.

The Claremont City Council hereby accepts with sincere appreciation a grant in the amount of \$10,000 from the New Hampshire Charitable Foundation (Common Sense Fund) to support the Police Department with a specific focus on the purchase of safety equipment.

Roll call vote:

O'Hearne - yes

Kier - yes

Sweetser - yes

Damren - yes

Matteau - yes
Koloski - yes
Contois - yes
Stone - yes
Lovett - yes
Motion carried 9-0.

Shugah Valley Snow Riders Annual Permission

Mr. Morris gave some background saying this is an annual permission. The City has granted use of the area across from the old Wheelabrator area for solar power; Shugah Valley Snow Riders will work with them for putting a trail through that area. Mr. Morris gave some background about the club, including that they help with trail maintenance.

There was some discussion about making this a 2-year permission.

A motion was made by Councilor Contois and seconded by Councilor Koloski to authorize the city manager, or his designees, to take such actions as may be necessary to issue a written Snowmobile Trail Permission, pursuant to RSA 215-C:8, to Shugah Valley Snow Riders, Inc. ~~for a period of one year, to go through December 2021.~~ This Permission is for use of designated City-owned land and class VI highways, which list is to be included with the Use Permission Form and is subject to all City and state rules and regulations pertaining to use of snowmobiles on public property. This Permission is granted subject to the following condition:

- 1. The City may close one or more trails on either City-owned land or class VI highways to snowmobile use as may be required for reasons including but not limited to trail conditions, maintenance and public safety.**

After some discussion, Councilor Contois changed the motion, to take out “to go through December 2021,” and make it “for a period of one year.” Councilor Koloski seconded the amendment.

The motion now reads:

A motion was made by Councilor Contois and seconded by Councilor Koloski to authorize the city manager, or his designees, to take such actions as may be necessary to issue a written Snowmobile Trail Permission, pursuant to RSA 215-C:8, to Shugah Valley Snow Riders, Inc. for a period of one year. This Permission is for use of designated City-owned land and class VI highways, which list is to be included with the Use Permission Form and is subject to all City and state rules and regulations pertaining to use of snowmobiles on public property. This Permission is granted subject to the following condition:

- 1. The City may close one or more trails on either City-owned land or class VI highways to snowmobile use as may be required for reasons including but not limited to trail conditions, maintenance and public safety.**

Roll call vote:

O'Hearne - yes

Kier - yes

Sweetser - yes

Damren - yes

Matteau - yes

Koloski - yes

Contois - yes

Stone - yes

Lovett - yes

Motion carried 9-0.

Elderly and Disabled Tax Exemptions; and Veterans Tax Credit Discussion

Assistant Mayor Damren, Chair of the Finance Committee gave some information:

Background

The Policy Committee unanimously recommended not adopting the All Veterans Tax Credit (at the Council's October 23 meeting, the Council had voted to increase the existing Veterans tax credit from \$125 to \$500). The Finance Committee devised a formula that could be used to calculate any changes required for Elderly tax exemptions, credits, income and asset limits.

The Formula

1. SNAP= Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program, updated annually
2. Data points required- A. NH HHS SNAP Amount (2019 2 Person Limit= 21,984);
B. Claremont Median Household Income per US Census (2018= 48,099)
3. Divide A by B= .46
4. Subtract .46 from 1 to get the inverse of .54, then add 1 to get the ratio of 1.54
5. Multiply answer in 3 by 2A above. Then divide that answer by 1.10.
6. Result is 30,800

When the Council, on January 10, 2020, voted based upon Mr. Hamilton's recommendations, the result for Elderly income limit for married was \$30,900 versus the formula which is \$30,800.

Discussion

SNAP was selected because both the state and federal government utilize SNAP in producing economic models. The median income information for Claremont also creates a correlation.

Recommendations

1. Use the formula for a year, calculating the tax shift involved with usage of the formula. If tax shift is deemed appropriate, then adopt the formula into existing ordinances.
2. Finance Committee concurs with the Policy Committee's recommendation not to adopt, at this time, the All Veterans Credit. The number of veterans in Claremont

is unknown and so cannot evaluate any resulting possible tax shift. The tax shift involved with increasing the existing Veterans credit from \$125 to \$500 was \$174,800.

Bob McCarthy, Interim Assessor, said the calculated values are based on 10 years of data.

A motion was made by Assistant Mayor Damren and seconded by Councilor Matteau to authorize use of a formula approach for our property tax credits and exemptions utilizing SNAP (Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program) data and Claremont median household income data as derived from state and/or federal services to calculate what those amounts should be. This is for a one-year period to be reevaluated after that year.

Roll call vote:

O'Hearne - yes

Kier - yes

Sweetser - yes

Damren - yes

Matteau - yes

Koloski - yes

Contois - yes

Stone - yes

Lovett - yes

Motion carried 9-0.

A motion was made by Assistant Mayor Damren and seconded by Councilor Matteau that at this time, the City of Claremont approves the recommendations from the Policy and Finance Committees to not adopt the All Veterans Credit.

Mayor Lovett recused herself as she is a veteran.

Roll call vote:

O'Hearne - yes

Kier - yes

Sweetser - yes

Damren - yes

Matteau - yes

Koloski - yes

Contois - yes

Stone - yes

Lovett - abstained

Motion carried 8-0, 1 abstain.

COMMITTEE REPORTS

Councilor Stone said because of the Governor's mask mandate, there was a unanimous vote of the Policy Committee to have no further action on a mask mandate.

FUTURE AGENDA ITEMS AND DIRECTIVES

None

CONSULTATION WITH LEGAL COUNSEL

None

ADJOURNMENT

At 9:29 p.m., a motion was made by Councilor Matteau and seconded by Councilor Kier to adjourn.

Roll call vote:

O'Hearne - yes

Kier - no

Sweetser - yes

Damren - yes

Matteau - yes

Koloski - yes

Contois - yes

Stone - yes

Lovett - yes

Motion carried 8-1.

Respectfully Submitted,

Dorée M. Russell
Clerk to the Council